Meta Platforms, Inc.

Frontier Coming Into Sight & Ad Growth Supports The Story For Now

After a jittery response to 3Q, META got back to business in 4Q. More impressive than the massive capex/opex growth is the ad rev trajectory eclipsing 30% in 1Q, papering over many investor concerns. META continues to set the pace for the digital ad industry, with AI option value still ahead.

The Key Take-Away: META reported revenue and OI largely in line and guided 1Q well above the Street. The implied 30% ad growth for 1Q is quite the achievement given META's scale at over a $200B ARR. Solid industry demand and continued performance gains from ad rec-sys improvements are driving the best growth the company has achieved in years. Zuckerberg sounded confident that the new AI lab is off to a solid start and may produce a frontier-quality model by the end of '26, with many other product launches along the way. This call likely doesn't go the full way to answering the critics, but META shares should continue to perform well as MSL ships models and innovative services. If META does indeed land a model at the frontier by year end, questions around the strategy and pace of investment should be answered.

Positives in 4Q: Noted above, the standout metric on the release was the ad revenue acceleration in 1Q. Management pointed to healthy demand and ad system improvements, coupled with high engagement growth on the major surfaces. The 18% impression growth was mostly driven by engagement and less so ad load. Importantly, the growth rate of conversions is outpacing impression growth, a very healthy backdrop heading into 2026. The AI strategy articulated on the call may leave some wanting more, but there was an underlying confidence and clearly a lot of new things in the works. 80% productivity improvement for engineers using code writing IDEs (among power users) and a new philosophy around work and team size we think bodes well for speeding up the pace of innovation at META. Operating losses at FRL are finally peaking in '26 and are expected to improve thereafter.

Negative Items to Monitor: Both the operating expense and capex growth exceeded most expectations for 2026, and weigh on EPS and FCF. We are now modeling negative FCF for '27 and '28, which is somewhat shocking to us but likely what we eventually see for all companies in the AI infrastructure arms race. While a few opex items may leverage in '27, most of this spending is likely to continue as the many new infrastructure projects slowly come online, and as operating expense-per-head increases with all the AI talent joining META. 4Q ad revenue was solid at 23% ex-fx but decelerated a bit from 3Q on the political comp.

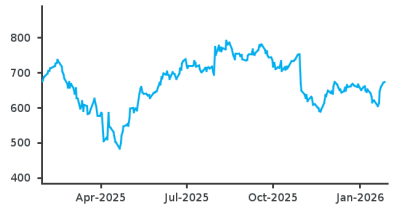
META	OVERWEIGHT Unchanged
U.S. Internet	POSITIVE Unchanged
Price Target	USD 800.00 raised 4% from USD 770.00
Price (28-Jan-26)	USD 668.73
Potential Upside/Downside	+19.6%

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Market Cap (USD mn)	1685913
Shares Outstanding (mn)	2521.07
Free Float (%)	99.86
52 Wk Avg Daily Volume (mn)	15.6
Dividend Yield (%)	0.31
Return on Equity TTM (%)	32.64
Current BVPS (USD)	76.98

Source: Bloomberg

Price Performance	Exchange-Nasdaq
52 Week range	USD 796.25-479.80



Source: IDC
Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

U.S. Internet

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Estimate Changes & Valuation: We increase our revenue growth forecasts somewhat meaningfully in '26 and onwards. Our margin assumptions have also been reduced modestly to account for the increased operating expense growth, but EPS increases 2% in '27. Our $800 price target (previously $770) is based on 25x EPS and 12x EBITDA on '27 estimates (unchanged).

META: Quarterly and Annual EPS (USD)

	2025	2026			2027			Change y/y	
FY Dec	Actual	Old	New	Cons	Old	New	Cons	2026	2027
Q1	6.96A	7.13E	7.78E	7.43E	7.90E	8.61E	8.17E	12%	11%
Q2	7.90A	8.13E	8.81E	8.58E	8.85E	9.63E	8.97E	12%	9%
Q3	8.47A	8.30E	8.80E	8.87E	8.94E	9.49E	9.73E	4%	8%
Q4	9.74A	9.45E	10.35E	10.11E	10.25E	11.09E	11.61E	6%	7%
Year	33.05A	33.02E	35.75E	33.31E	35.95E	38.83E	38.46E	8%	9%
P/E	20.2		18.7			17.2			

Consensus numbers are from Bloomberg received on 28-Jan-2026; 13:50 GMT
Source: Barclays Research

U.S. Internet POSITIVE

Meta Platforms, Inc. (META) OVERWEIGHT

Income statement ($bn)	2025A	2026E	2027E	2028E	CAGR
Revenue	201	254	302	347	19.9%
Gross profit	166	204	239	272	17.9%
EBITDA (adj)	122	146	176	208	19.3%
EBIT (adj)	104	115	126	134	8.8%
Pre-tax income (adj) ($mn)	86	88	94	97	4.0%
Net income (adj)	85	92	101	107	7.9%
EPS (adj) ($)	33.05	35.75	38.83	40.83	7.3%
Diluted shares (bn)	2.6	2.6	2.6	2.6	0.6%
DPS ($)	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	N/A

Margin and return data	2025A	2026E	2027E	2028E	Average
EBITDA (adj) margin (%)	60.9	57.3	58.2	59.9	59.1
EBIT (adj) margin (%)	51.6	45.3	41.8	38.6	44.3
Pre-tax (adj) margin (%)	42.8	34.7	31.2	27.9	34.1
Net (adj) margin (%)	42.3	36.3	33.5	30.9	35.7
ROIC (%)	25.1	18.1	17.9	15.2	19.1
ROE (%)	30.2	28.6	22.1	17.5	24.6

Balance sheet and cash flow ($bn)	2025A	2026E	2027E	2028E	CAGR
Tangible fixed assets	176	276	397	533	44.6%
Intangible fixed assets	25	25	25	25	0.0%
Cash and equivalents	36	35	26	8	-38.4%
Total assets	366	475	593	718	25.2%
Short and long-term debt	59	59	59	59	0.0%
Other long-term liabilities	25	25	25	25	0.0%
Total liabilities	149	162	175	188	8.0%
Net debt/(funds)	23	23	33	50	30.1%
Shareholders' equity	217	313	418	531	34.7%
Change in working capital	-1	4	6	6	N/A
Cash flow from operations	116	135	166	198	19.6%
Capital expenditure	-70	-130	-170	-210	N/A
Free cash flow	46	5	-4	-12	N/A

Valuation and leverage metrics	2025A	2026E	2027E	2028E	Average
P/E (adj) (x)	20.2	18.7	17.2	16.4	18.1
EV/sales (x)	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.2	0.1
EV/EBITDA (adj) (x)	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.3	0.2
FCF yield (%)	187.5	18.6	-12.3	-23.6	42.6
Dividend yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Net debt/EBITDA (adj) (x)	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.2

Selected Operating Metrics ($)	2025A	2026E	2027E	2028E
Advertising revenue ($bn)	196	249	295	339
Payments & other fees revenue ($mn)	5	6	7	7
.				
DAUs (mn)	2,166	2,214	2,263	2,313
Advertising revenue per DAU	14.47	17.10	19.55	21.62
Payments & other fees revenue per DAU	0.53	0.63	0.72	0.79

Note: FY End Dec
Source: Company data, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Price (28-Jan-2026)	**USD 668.73**
Price Target	**USD 800.00**

Why OVERWEIGHT?

We believe META is the best pure play in consumer internet around mobile advertising and it continues to take a large share of mobile advertising budgets. We expect fundamentals to remain strong going forward.

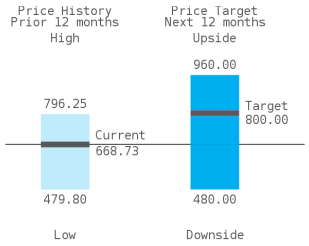
Upside case **USD 960.00**

As mobile monetization improves in the coming years, we expect META to benefit from this. We believe both core FB and Instagram have room to grow, and Whatsapp and Messenger will provide upside as META starts to monetize them in the coming years.

Downside case **USD 480.00**

The transition to video will negatively impact margins due to revenue sharing agreements. The company is also reaching a ceiling in terms of ad load in core FB.

Upside/Downside scenarios



META 4Q25 Earnings

FIGURE 1. 4Q25 Quarterly Comparison - Actual vs Barclays Estimates

Quarterly Comparison versus Barclays Estimates (USD in bn, unless noted)	4Q25 Actual	Barclays Estimate	Delta	Consensus	Prior Year Quarter	Change / Prior Year	Prior Quarter	Change / Prior Quarter
Key Metrics								
Advertising Revenue by Geography								
US & Canada	25.643	24.961	3%		20.982	22%	21.331	20%
Europe	14.198	13.673	4%		11.154	27%	12.072	18%
Asia	10.893	11.879	-8%		9.012	21%	10.020	9%
ROW	7.403	7.412	0%		5.635	31%	6.659	11%
Total Advertising Revenue	**58.137**	**57.926**		**56.980**	**46.783**	**24%**	**50.082**	**16%**
FRL/Payments Revs	1.602	1.222	31%	1.671	1.602	0%	1.160	38%
Income Statement								
Net Revenue	**59.893**	**59.148**	**1.3%**	**58.410**	**48.385**	**24%**	**51.242**	**17%**
Cost of revenues	10.599	10.907	-3%		8.559	24%	8.917	19%
Gross Profit	49.294	48.241	2.2%	47.418	39.826	24%	42.325	16%
% Gross Margin	82.3%	81.6%	74 bps	81.0%	82.3%	-01 bps	82.6%	-29 bps
Marketing & Sales	3.164	3.947	-20%		2.987	6%	2.613	21%
Research & Development	12.032	11.786	2%		8.674	39%	10.330	16%
General & Administrative	3.464	2.848	22%		0.538	544%	3.292	5%
Total Operating Expenses	24.549	23.792	3%		16.461	49%	21.790	13%
GAAP Operating Income	24.745	24.450	1%	23.920	23.365	6%	20.535	21%
PF Operating Income	30.635	29.660	3%		26.077	17%	26.090	17%
Adjusted EBITDA	**36.046**	**35.336**	**2.0%**	**35.115**	**30.537**	**18%**	**31.053**	**16%**
% Margins	60.2%	59.7%	44 bps		63.1%	-293 bps	60.6%	--
GAAP EPS	**$8.88**	**$8.25**	**8%**	**$8.21**	**$8.02**	**11%**	**$1.05**	**$7.43**

Consensus via StreetAccount & Bloomberg
Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports

Estimate Changes

FIGURE 2. Estimate Changes

	1Q26E			2Q26E			2026E			2027E		
	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta
Revs by segments												
Advertising Revenue	54.247	50.088	8.3%	59.154	55.073	7.4%	248.567	233.044	6.7%	295.020	269.571	9.4%
FRL and Payments Revenue	1.244	1.019	22.0%	1.277	0.974	31.1%	5.620	4.258	32.0%	6.538	4.494	45.5%
Net Revenues	**55.491**	**51.107**	**8.6%**	**60.431**	**56.047**	**7.8%**	**254.187**	**237.302**	**7.1%**	**301.558**	**274.065**	**10.0%**
Cost of Revenues	10.823	9.968	8.6%	11.805	10.949	7.8%	50.053	47.183	6.1%	62.391	55.860	11.7%
Gross Profit	44.668	41.139	8.6%	48.626	45.099	7.8%	204.134	190.119	7.4%	239.167	218.205	9.6%
Margin	80.5%	80.5%	00 bps	80.5%	80.5%	00 bps	80.3%	80.1%	19 bps	79.3%	79.6%	-31 bps
Operating Expenses:												
Marketing & Sales	3.861	3.556	8.6%	4.095	3.798	7.8%	16.537	16.350	1.1%	21.137	19.574	8.0%
Research & Development	13.104	12.069	8.6%	13.084	12.135	7.8%	58.195	54.330	7.1%	75.074	66.863	12.3%
General & Administrative	2.711	2.497	8.6%	3.079	2.856	7.8%	14.205	12.520	13.5%	16.835	14.449	16.5%
Stock-Based Compensation	5.716	4.753	20.3%	6.450	5.422	19.0%	27.113	22.212	22.1%	32.162	24.276	32.5%
Total Operating Expenses	25.392	22.875	11.0%	26.708	24.210	10.3%	116.050	105.411	10.1%	145.208	125.162	16.0%
Operating Income - GAAP	19.276	18.264	5.5%	21.918	20.888	4.9%	88.084	84.708	4.0%	93.958	93.042	1.0%
Non-GAAP Operating Income	**24.992**	**23.018**	**8.6%**	**28.368**	**26.310**	**7.8%**	**115.197**	**106.920**	**7.7%**	**126.120**	**117.319**	**7.5%**
Depreciation & Amortization	5.821	6.313	-7.8%	6.967	7.456	-6.6%	30.439	31.326	-2.8%	49.473	48.515	2.0%
Stock Based Compensation	5.716	4.753	20.3%	6.450	5.422	19.0%	27.113	22.212	22.1%	32.162	24.276	32.5%
Adjusted EBITDA	**30.813**	**29.331**	**5.1%**	**35.335**	**33.766**	**4.6%**	**145.636**	**138.246**	**5.3%**	**175.593**	**165.834**	**5.9%**
Margin	55.5%	57.4%	-186 bps	58.5%	60.2%	-177 bps	57.3%	58.3%	-96 bps	58.2%	60.5%	-228 bps
Pretax Income - GAAP	**19.276**	**18.264**	**5.5%**	**21.918**	**20.888**	**4.9%**	**88.084**	**84.708**	**4.0%**	**93.958**	**93.042**	**1.0%**
Income Tax Expense (benefit)	2.699	2.557	5.5%	3.069	2.924	4.9%	12.332	11.859	4.0%	13.154	13.026	1.0%
Reported Net Income	16.578	15.707	5.5%	18.849	17.964	4.9%	75.752	72.849	4.0%	80.804	80.016	1.0%
GAAP Earnings per Share	$6.45	$6.08	6.0%	$7.32	$6.94	5.4%	$29.39	$28.13	4.5%	$31.10	$30.65	1.5%

Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports

Valuation

FIGURE 3. META Valuation

Meta -- Valuation Worksheet

($ in billions, except per share amounts)

Current Price (After Hours)	$715.51			
Diluted Shares Outstanding	2.6			
Current Market Cap	1835			
Less: Cash and Cash Equivalents	81.6			
Plus: Debt	58.7			
Enterprise Value	1812.4			
Price to Earnings	**2025E**	**2026E**	**2027E**	**2028E**
GAAP EPS	$23.49	$29.39	$31.10	$31.76
Current P/E multiple	30.5x	24.3x	23.0x	22.5x
Target Multiple	**25.0x**	**25.0x**	**25.0x**	**25.0x**
Implied Stock Price on Forward EPS	**$585**	**$735**	**$775**	**$795**
EV to EBITDA	**2025E**	**2026E**	**2027E**	**2028E**
Adjusted EBITDA	122.3	145.6	175.6	207.8
Current EV/EBITDA Multiple	14.8x	12.4x	10.3x	8.7x
Target Multiple	**12.0x**	**12.0x**	**12.0x**	**12.0x**
Enterprise Value	1467.8	1747.6	2107.1	2493.2
Plus: YE Cash	81.6	81.1	71.7	54.1
Less: YE Debt	58.7	58.7	58.7	58.7
Less: Minority Interest	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Equity Market Capitalization	1490.7	1770.0	2120.0	2488.6
FY End Projected Sharecount	2.6	2.6	2.6	2.6
Implied Stock Price on Forward EBITDA	**$580**	**$685**	**$815**	**$945**
	$580	**$710**	**$800**	**$870**
			$800	

Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports. Price as of 7:45PM EST on 1/28/26.

FIGURE 4. META Income Statement

Meta -- Quarterly Earnings Analysis	Dec-23	Dec-24	Dec-25	Mar-26	Jun-26	Sep-26	Dec-26	Dec-26	Dec-27	Dec-28
FY End December	2023A	2024A	2025A	1QE	2QE	3QE	4QE	2026E	2027E	2028E
Advertising revenue	131.948	160.632	196.174	54.247	59.154	62.213	72.952	248.567	295.020	339.288
Payments and other fees revenue	2.953	3.868	4.791	1.244	1.277	1.372	1.727	5.620	6.538	7.288
Net revenue	**134.901**	**164.500**	**200.965**	**55.491**	**60.431**	**63.586**	**74.679**	**254.187**	**301.558**	**346.576**
Cost of Revenues	25.218	29.107	35.030	10.823	11.805	12.496	14.929	50.053	62.391	74.300
Gross Profit	**109.683**	**135.393**	**165.935**	**44.668**	**48.626**	**51.090**	**59.749**	**204.134**	**239.167**	**272.276**
Operating Expenses:										
Marketing & Sales	11.349	10.321	11.043	3.861	4.095	3.878	4.702	16.537	21.137	26.029
Research & Development	27.054	30.189	39.947	13.104	13.084	14.726	17.281	58.195	75.074	93.212
General & Administrative	10.502	8.813	11.244	2.711	3.079	4.085	4.330	14.205	16.835	19.345
Stock-Based Compensation	14.027	16.690	20.426	5.716	6.450	7.211	7.736	27.113	32.162	36.967
Amortization of Intangibles	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Total Operating Expenses	62.932	66.013	82.659	25.392	26.708	29.900	34.049	116.050	145.208	175.553
Operating Income	46.751	69.380	83.276	19.276	21.918	21.190	25.700	88.084	93.958	96.723
Depreciation & Amortization	11.177	15.498	18.616	5.821	6.967	8.465	9.186	30.439	49.473	74.079
Stock Based Compensation	14.027	16.690	20.426	5.716	6.450	7.211	7.736	27.113	32.162	36.967
Adjusted EBITDA	**77.277**	**101.705**	**122.318**	**30.813**	**35.335**	**36.866**	**42.622**	**145.636**	**175.593**	**207.768**
Interest expense	0.677	1.284	2.657	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Other (expense) income, net	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Pretax Income	47.428	70.664	85.933	19.276	21.918	21.190	25.700	88.084	93.958	96.723
Income Tax Expense (benefit)	8.331	8.304	25.475	2.699	3.069	2.967	3.598	12.332	13.154	13.541
Reported Net Income	39.097	62.360	60.458	16.578	18.849	18.223	22.102	75.752	80.804	83.182
Non-GAAP Operating Income	66.100	86.207	103.702	24.992	28.368	28.401	33.436	115.197	126.120	133.690
Non-GAAP Net Income	53.422	69.993	85.087	19.994	22.694	22.721	26.749	92.158	100.896	106.952
Diluted Earnings per Share										
GAAP Earnings per Share	$14.92	$23.91	$23.49	$6.45	$7.32	$7.06	$8.55	$29.39	$31.10	$31.76
Pro forma Earnings per Share	**$20.39**	**$26.83**	**$33.05**	**$7.78**	**$8.81**	**$8.80**	**$10.35**	**$35.75**	**$38.83**	**$40.83**
Diluted Shares Outstanding	2.620	2.609	2.574	2.570	2.575	2.580	2.586	2.578	2.599	2.619
Pro forma Shares Outstanding	2.620	2.609	2.574	2.570	2.575	2.580	2.586	2.578	2.599	2.619
Other Metrics										
Peer Defined Free Cash Flow	43.847	54.072	46.109	0.193	2.085	0.585	1.809	4.672	(4.250)	(12.308)
Free Cash Flow per Share	$16.74	$20.73	$17.91	$0.08	$0.81	$0.23	$0.70	$1.81	($1.64)	($4.70)
Margin Analysis										
Gross Profit Margin	81.3%	82.3%	82.6%	80.5%	80.5%	80.3%	80.0%	80.3%	79.3%	78.6%
Marketing & Sales as % of Net Revenue	8.4%	6.3%	5.5%	7.0%	6.8%	6.1%	6.3%	6.5%	7.0%	7.5%
Research & Development as % of Net Revenue	20.1%	18.4%	19.9%	23.6%	21.7%	23.2%	23.1%	22.9%	24.9%	26.9%
General & Administrative as % of Net Revenue	7.8%	5.4%	5.6%	4.9%	5.1%	6.4%	5.8%	5.6%	5.6%	5.6%
Total Operating Expenses as % of Net Revenue	46.7%	40.1%	41.1%	45.8%	44.2%	47.0%	45.6%	45.7%	48.2%	50.7%
Operating Margin	34.7%	42.2%	41.4%	34.7%	36.3%	33.3%	34.4%	34.7%	31.2%	27.9%
Non-GAAP Operating Margin	49.0%	52.4%	51.6%	45.0%	46.9%	44.7%	44.8%	45.3%	41.8%	38.6%
Adjusted EBITDA Margin	57.3%	61.8%	60.9%	55.5%	58.5%	58.0%	57.1%	57.3%	58.2%	59.9%
Incremental EBITDA Margin	128.2%	82.5%	56.5%	39.5%	44.3%	47.1%	44.5%	43.8%	63.2%	71.5%
Effective Tax Rate	17.6%	11.8%	29.6%	14.0%	14.0%	14.0%	14.0%	14.0%	14.0%	14.0%
Reported Net Income	29.0%	37.9%	30.1%	29.9%	31.2%	28.7%	29.6%	29.8%	26.8%	24.0%
Year Over Year Growth										
Advertising revenue	**16.1%**	**21.7%**	**22.1%**	**31.1%**	**27.0%**	**24.2%**	**25.5%**	**26.7%**	**18.7%**	**15.0%**
Payments and other fees revenue	-0.5%	31.0%	23.9%	34.9%	34.0%	18.3%	-1.6%	17.3%	16.3%	11.5%
Net Revenue	15.7%	21.9%	22.2%	31.1%	27.2%	24.1%	24.7%	26.5%	18.6%	14.9%
Cost of Revenues	3.0%	15.4%	20.3%	48.2%	43.7%	40.1%	40.9%	42.9%	24.6%	19.1%
Gross Profit	19.1%	23.4%	22.6%	27.6%	23.7%	20.7%	21.2%	23.0%	17.2%	13.8%
Operating Income	61.5%	48.4%	20.0%	9.8%	7.2%	3.2%	3.9%	5.8%	6.7%	2.9%
Adjusted EBITDA	**43.6%**	**31.6%**	**20.3%**	**20.4%**	**19.3%**	**18.7%**	**18.2%**	**19.1%**	**20.6%**	**18.3%**
Reported Net Income	68.5%	59.5%	-3.1%	-0.4%	2.8%	572.7%	-2.9%	25.3%	6.7%	2.9%
GAAP Earnings per Share	73.4%	60.2%	-1.8%	0.4%	2.6%	570.5%	-3.7%	25.1%	5.8%	2.1%
Pro forma Earnings per Share	52.7%	31.6%	23.2%	11.8%	11.6%	4.0%	6.2%	8.2%	8.6%	5.2%

Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports

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Primary Stocks (Ticker, Date, Price)
Meta Platforms, Inc. (META, 28-Jan-2026, USD 668.73), Overweight/Positive, CD/CE/FA/J/K/M/N

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Meta Platforms, Inc. (META / META)

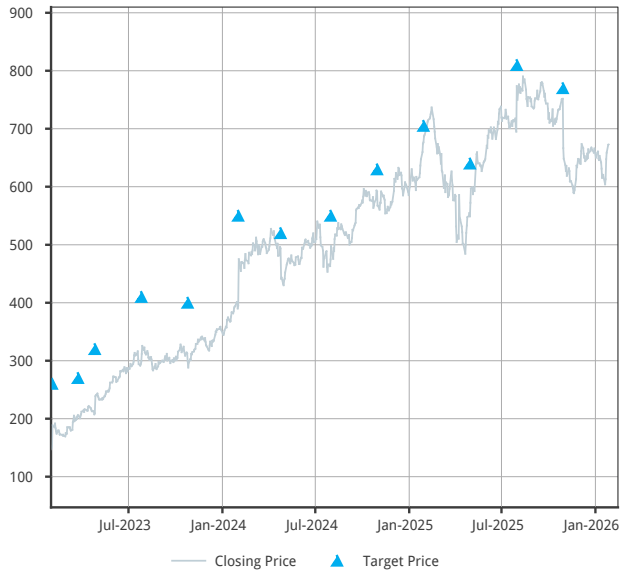
Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 668.73** (28-Jan-2026)

Rating and Price Target Chart - USD (as of 28-Jan-2026)

Currency=USD



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target
29-Oct-2025	751.67		770.00
31-Jul-2025	695.21		810.00
30-Apr-2025	549.00		640.00
29-Jan-2025	676.49		705.00
30-Oct-2024	591.80		630.00
31-Jul-2024	474.83		550.00
24-Apr-2024	493.50		520.00
01-Feb-2024	394.78		550.00
25-Oct-2023	299.53		400.00
26-Jul-2023	298.57		410.00
26-Apr-2023	209.40		320.00
24-Mar-2023	204.28		270.00
01-Feb-2023	153.12		260.00

On 28-Jan-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 165.00.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our $800 price target is based on an average of 25x EPS and 12x EBITDA on our FY27E estimates.

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